Mind Mender

THE YEARS 2020 AND 2021, dominated by the challenges posed by the Covid-19 pandemic, were possibly the most testing time in Dr Pratima Murthy's career. "We had outbreaks in our closed wards. So, we had to constantly be vigilant, look after our students, our residents, faculty and establish separate Covid wards for patients with psychiatric illness," says Pratima, who was the head of psychiatry at the National Institute of Mental Health and Neuro Sciences (NIMHANS) in Bengaluru then. Alongside this, teaching programmes and examinations for postgraduate students all had to go on as usual. "We had to constantly innovate and respond to emergencies much, much more than at any other time," says Pratima, who took over as director in June 2021. This streamlining of services, she says, helped make the system more responsive later.

Pratima, who was born and raised in Bengaluru, is the first doctor in her family. Her husband is a pulmonologist, and they have two daughters—one of them is currently pursuing her MD in Psychiatry.

Pratima's school and college were on the same thoroughfare, Palace Road, running through the city's heart, not far from the Gandhinagar locality where the family stayed. From the rooftop of her home next to the cricket pavilion of Central College, they could watch matches, including the internationals that featured cricket greats such as Gary Sobers. Pratima, incidentally, was the wicket-keeper in her school team.

Psychiatry was somewhat serendipitous, she recalls. "It was always fascinating to know how the human mind works in health and disease," says Pratima, who gave herself three months to figure out if she liked it. "The three months became six months and I never looked back." Her MD thesis was on alcoholism—the study of addiction treatment went on to become a lifelong pursuit. "The addiction does horrendous things to both the person as well as their family members. But once you take the person out of the addiction, there's a sea change...they are some of the best individuals, caring and intellectually endowed," she says. "It's very important, therefore, not to stigmatise people with addiction but to help and support them."

In her childhood, Pratima learnt from her experiences that 'even when you have done your best, it doesn't automatically mean that you can get to the next step'. "And therefore, giving your best is the critical thing," she says. Take it from the good doctor! ■

–Ajay Sukumaran

BIGGEST INSPIRATION

"My patients... some of their family members have been so steadfast, so loyal, so grateful for what they have"

CHILDHOOD LESSON

She stood first in Class II but had to repeat a year because there was an age regulation

ACCOMPLISHMENT

As head of psychiatry during the Covid years, she held responsibility for nearly 500 patients at NIMHANS, India's biggest mental healthcare institution



Dr Pratima Murthy, *62*
Director, National Institute of Mental Health and Neuro Sciences, Bengaluru

HEMANT MISHRA